Fettuccine Alfredo with Lemon Pepper Chicken

Main dishes | Stovetop & prep

Before you start

Equipment: pasta pot and one large skillet; use the chicken skillet for the sauce. Chicken: about 3-5 minutes per side for thin cutlets, to 165°F; rest 5 minutes. Sauce simmer: 5-8 minutes. Reserve pasta water before draining; Parmesan is divided.

Ingredients

Matching letters and colors = one prep bowl. Charcoal = keep separate.

Bowl A - Sauce seasonings

Bowl B - Chicken seasonings

- [ ] 1 1/4 lb boneless chicken breasts, sliced into thin cutlets, or boneless thighs
- [ ] 1 Tbsp + 1 tsp olive oil, for the chicken
- [ ] 2 tsp lemon pepper seasoning [Bowl B]
- [ ] 5/8 tsp garlic powder (a rounded 1/2 tsp is fine) [Bowl B]
- [ ] Salt for chicken, only if lemon pepper seasoning is unsalted
- [ ] 1 Tbsp butter, for finishing the chicken
- [ ] Zest of 1/2-1 lemon, plus a small squeeze of juice
- [ ] 1 lb fettuccine
- [ ] 6 Tbsp butter
- [ ] 1 garlic clove, minced
- [ ] 1 1/2 cups heavy cream
- [ ] Up to 1/4 tsp salt, for sauce, to taste [Bowl A]
- [ ] 1 1/4 cups shredded Parmesan, divided: about 5/8 cup for sauce; remaining 5/8 cup for pasta
- [ ] Up to 1/4 tsp black pepper, for sauce, to taste [Bowl A]
- [ ] 2 Tbsp Italian parsley, chopped, optional

1. Cook lemon pepper chicken

1. Pat 1 1/4 lb chicken dry. Season with 2 tsp lemon pepper and 5/8 tsp garlic powder; add salt only if the lemon pepper seasoning is unsalted.

2. Heat 1 Tbsp + 1 tsp olive oil in a skillet over medium-high heat. Sear chicken about 3-5 minutes per side for thin cutlets, longer for thick pieces or thighs, until the center reaches 165°F. Cook in batches if needed.

3. Transfer the hot chicken to a clean resting plate. Add 1 Tbsp butter, zest of 1/2-1 lemon, and a small squeeze of lemon juice on the plate; turn the chicken to coat. Rest at least 5 minutes while making the pasta and sauce, then slice. Keep the lemon finish on the plate, out of the sauce skillet.

2. Cook pasta; start sauce while it boils

1. Cook 1 lb fettuccine in salted boiling water according to the package. Reserve a little pasta water before draining.

2. Reduce the chicken skillet to medium-low heat; let it cool briefly if very hot. Pour off excess oil and wipe away blackened seasoning, keeping the golden-brown bits. Add 6 Tbsp butter, then 1 minced garlic clove; cook gently 30-60 seconds until fragrant.

3. Pour in 1 1/2 cups heavy cream and gently scrape up the golden-brown chicken bits. Bring to a gentle simmer and cook 5-8 minutes to reduce slightly.

3. Add cheese and combine

1. Reduce the heat to low. From 1 1/4 cups shredded Parmesan, whisk about half (5/8 cup) into the sauce until smooth and melted. Taste, then add up to 1/4 tsp salt and 1/4 tsp black pepper as needed; the chicken seasoning and browned bits already add salt and pepper.

2. Toss sauce with the drained pasta and remaining 5/8 cup Parmesan. Loosen with reserved pasta water as needed.

3. Top with the sliced lemon pepper chicken. Garnish with optional 2 Tbsp Italian parsley.

Notes

Use freshly shredded refrigerated Parmesan for best melting. Finish the chicken with butter, lemon zest, and a small squeeze of juice on its resting plate. Keep this lemon finish out of the sauce skillet. Golden-brown chicken bits add flavor and may tint the Alfredo slightly golden; discard blackened bits to avoid bitterness.

Alfredo base adapted from the linked source; lemon pepper chicken added as a personal variation.